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Sherrie Maricle

Sherrie Maricle was born in Buffalo, New York on September 2, 1963. She currently balances a career as a drummer, band leader, composer and educator. Sherrie has performed with Clark Terry, Dizzy Gillespie and Slam Stewart, and records with the Diva Big Band and her quintet, Five Play.

Sherrie was interviewed in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 18, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are in Clearwater Beach at the Arbors Jazz Fest and my name is Monk Rowe. I'm very pleased to have Sherrie Maricle with me today. And usually I say saxophonist somebody or, you know, keyboardist, but I'm not sure which to go first with you. I was looking at your write-up and I don't know how you handle your life.

SM: I was hoping you could tell me how I should identify myself. That's been my problem all along.

MR: Let's say musician.

SM: Okay.

MR: Can we do that?

SM: Yeah. I have a lot of different things that I do. And every time I look back on my career I wonder if — it's always been really interesting to me and I think kept me motivated, highly motivated, about music in general. But then sometimes I wonder well if I would have just picked one thing would I have excelled to a higher level. And I don't know if I would have or not. I'm not sure.

MR: Right.

SM: Because the way it is now it's just, every day is a thrill to be a musician.

MR: You seem to be one of the few people I've met who manages to balance a good deal of performing with your educational obligations. Would you say that's true?

SM: Yeah. Sometimes it's a struggle to balance it and that's probably the most major difficulty that I have. I'm lucky to be at a school, right at New York University, well part time there first of all, even though I direct the entire percussion program. And also the school seems to be flexible with their performing arts faculty. They see merit in us going around the world and mentioning where I work. And that's what attracts some students. But it's true, it's always a dilemma, like if one of my bands is going on the road for ten weeks and I have to hope that I can get out of my job.

MR: What to do with the students. Do you have subs you call in?

SM: Yeah. I've only taken off actually one full semester from school when my band had, I think we had a twelve week tour. I said to my boss I've been here for ten years, I need to get out for a semester. And he let me go, which is nice.

MR: Yeah. A little sabbatical, right?

SM: Yeah. I don't know if that's common for part time people. But anyway he let me out so that was good. Other times it's a lot of well-qualified subs, which are easy to find in New York. There's a lot of good players, teachers.

MR: Was Buffalo a — oh let's say fertile musical atmosphere to grow up in?

SM: I actually grew up in Endicott, New York, but born in Buffalo, and I go to Buffalo at least a couple of times a year. My friends are still there and a lot of my family was still there. Where I grew up was a town called Endicott, New York, and Binghamton. Of course you know where that is. And that was amazing to grow up there. Slam Stewart, the jazz bass player, lived there, and every big band that there was came through town. Buddy Rich and Woody Herman and Count Basie. I saw all of those bands. And I was lucky to have a teacher that took me, because when I was eleven a teacher took me to see Buddy Rich and his Killer Force Orchestra, and that was when I was eleven that I said that was exactly what I wanted to do then was just play the drums. And I never changed, ever, from that.

MR: Wow. You anticipated a question.

SM: Oh I did?

MR: That's good. I was going to ask if there was a kind of pivotal moment when you were young, seeing or hearing something?

SM: I remember, well that definitely set me right off into my direction and I literally never, ever thought of anything else. I remember telling my eighth grade teacher, I know exactly what I'm going to do, and I have to move to New York. I mean really, I remember having this conversation with this guy when I was twelve years old. But prior to that when you were first allowed to take musical instruments, fourth grade or whatever, I went up to the teacher and, "I want to play the trumpet." "No, girls don't play the trumpet, here's a metal clarinet" and he gave me this thing to squeak and squawk on. I was horrible and he was horrible and I quit. I was like I don't want to play music, this is terrible, this teacher, you know. And then the teacher actually called the house, I think he was a little unsteady, like unstable, called my mother and said, "she is so talented." And I was really, I was terrible. I could barely make a sound on this metal clarinet. But he begged for me to be in the school band so I went back. And then somehow I started on the cello and played that for like three years and then desperately one day someone needed someone to hit the bass drum. And I was like, "I'll do it." Any chance to hit something. So I went back and

MR: Interesting.

SM: Yeah. But then when I saw Buddy, that was it.

MR: At age eleven.

SM: Yeah, eleven, um hum.

MR: And that's when you kind of started on the whole drum set?

SM: I actually pleaded with my mother to buy me a drum set which was like there is just no way, you know, my daughter is not playing the drums kind of attitude. But then after my pleading and screaming I remember she bought me a, I begged for a snare drum, which is the first drum you would get, and she came home and didn't know a drum from anything, and went to the music store and the guy told her, "this is a snare drum." And this was this big like funky weird brown tom-tom, and just the fact that she bought it for me, I've told her now but I could never tell her for years it was the wrong drum. So I'd be practicing on this tom-tom and then I finally got into drum set when I was in high school. I was terrified to try out for the jazz band and another good teacher actually said something like, "what are you stupid? Just go ahead." Because there were no girls in it. No girls had ever played the drums anyway. So he was encouraging.

MR: Were you something of a — I don't want to, don't take this personal, an oddity in your school, being the girl stage band drummer? Was that kind of like strange?

SM: Probably being a good one.

MR: Yeah.

SM: I don't mean that in a conceited way but I took it really seriously since I knew that's what I wanted to do for a living, I was maybe more serious than other girls who were in the band playing other instruments. I think like a lot of the women in my band have had similar experiences. They were very dedicated and very serious at a pretty young age. You know I'm pretty passionate about it so that, it wasn't weird with my other friends who were interested in pursuing the same thing, but they were all boys.

MR: Is there a teacher along the way that you credit with really helping you along this path?

SM: In Binghamton, which we were talking about before, just the area itself, there was a guy named Al Hamme who ran a lot of the jazz bands up there.

MR: Right, I was going to ask about that.

SM: First I started in college at SUNY Binghamton, the state university — I started at Ithaca then I finished at SUNY and Al liked the way I played and subsequently I went into all of his bands, and he booked a lot of the shows in Binghamton and I played all the time there. It was like the best possible way to train to do anything in music was to be playing in his big bands and his small bands and he introduced me to Slam Stewart and I played with Slam a lot and got to play on Slam's last album with him, and Al introduced me to a

came through town, every show, I played percussion for all of them. So it was phenomenal. So that was that phase of my life. But really somebody who opened my eyes unbelievably to music was Stanley Kay when I came to New York in 1986. I met him a few years later and he's like to me a genius and so inspirational to me, not just about music, but the music business, about drumming, about jazz, about big band playing.

MR: Really.

SM: Yeah because he was the drummer with Josephine Baker, Patti Page and Frankie Laine and of course Buddy Rich's assistant drummer and he managed the Buddy Rich band for 30 years. So it's ironic that my business partner and my best friend, Stanley, was probably with Buddy in Binghamton when I was eleven.

MR: Oh neat.

SM: Like watching it. And not realizing that there was this silly girl like staring in awe.

MR: Did your mother ever, or I shouldn't say ever, at what point did she become adjusted to the idea that you were going to become a professional musician?

SM: I think when she — she didn't come to all the high school performances but some of them, and I think — I won't say when I started to make money, but when she heard people clapping. She's like oh that's my daughter. And like the funniest thing was in New York when I got to sub in my first Broadway show, which is a good aspiration for a musician, it's a good job and everything and it's fun. So I was subbing for one of my friends on a stage part to the "Cabaret" revival, which was I think it was in '89, with Joel Grey. That was a couple of years ago, and that was the very first time I'd ever done it. I had to memorize the music. So they wheel the all-girl band in there with their fishnet stockings and their skimpy little sequins costumes out on the stage. And I'm looking in the fourth row and it's my mother going like this, like waving. And I'm like oh my God, this is not Binghamton High School stuff. You know, sinking in horror.

MR: Right. Poking the people next to her, that's my daughter, this is New York, this is Broadway.

SM: It was embarrassing.

MR: That's a nice story though.

SM: It's cute, yeah, it was cute. But I think now of course she's happy but I think it was a big adjustment, because she didn't understand anything about it. She's like please study computers, that's what she always said to us.

MR: Isn't that interesting where your musical genes come from.

SM: Hey I don't know. I mean I really grew up in a country & western household. That's all my mom listens to.

MR: Really.

SM: She likes Irish folk music too. Her family, there are a lot of Irish relatives. I like that also. But every single morning we woke up and one of those two styles of music was blaring through the house. I just remember also being a kid and spinning the dial on my radio in bed one night, I couldn't sleep, and I accidentally twirled down to WSKG public radio in Binghamton. And I remember the song it was a Booker Ervin's version of "The Lamp is Low." And I heard that and I was like what is that. And it was jazz. And I didn't know what it was and I really, really liked it. So that was an accident too. I mean my mother wouldn't have known like where to even look for a jazz radio station. You know, it wasn't her interest. So I found that by accident, you know along with learning the different instruments, would be bugging my teachers and they gave me a lot of recordings and so I just automatically loved it. I think everybody does that goes into jazz. I don't think it's a study or like really even a choice. I really don't think it's a choice.

MR: I think you're right. I think, one fella described it as an illness.

SM: Yeah. I mean you'd be insane to pick it as an art field or a career. And parents sometimes, like at parent-teacher days or career day at college, you know, "excuse me, what's the starting salary for a jazz musician?" And you just have to say, "uh m'am, there's a great benefit package with that."

MR: Yeah. That's like an oxymoron, a starting salary for a jazz musician I guess.

SM: I know. Or any musician. So then in the role of teacher sometimes I see really such unbelievable talent in the students. And even in the time I've lived in New York and just see the change in the face of jazz there with the shut down of clubs. I played for eight years at the Village Gate, which was a great club on Bleecker Street. Every single Saturday. I mean I got this job like the second year I lived in New York and I had it for eight years, just playing with my own trio. And it was a jam session, it was four hours, it was like unbelievable training for me, speaking to an audience and just, you know, playing all the time. And then that club closed and they used to have jam sessions, the Blue Note had a jam session every night except Monday. Every night 'til 4 A.M. because I used to go when I first moved, and there were all these loads of opportunities to play. The Village Vanguard was $5 and you could see Mel Lewis' band. Now the cost is astronomical to go anywhere. The students are struggling, there is nowhere for them to play. Like there's no outlets for them.

MR: Well that was something I was going to ask you about, especially being one of the things you do with IAJE. I attended the festival in January and it was breathtaking almost to see the amount of people and everybody there. But I wondered, is it translating down to that level of places to play and jam sessions and all that kind of thing?

SM: It's like it's very bizarre but I can't remember who I was speaking with, maybe

artist is really going into academia now, and into the colleges. And you can tell by the way the students play. It's so interesting that it's — I won't say cookie cutter — because all the kids, certain ones have different talents, but there's so much information about how to learn. So much information and so little innovation, you know, in what the new artists, the young artists, are doing. It's either duplicating styles or attitudes or whatever you call it, artists that came before them, or else it's everybody trying to play like John Coltrane. And you can really easily because a lot of what he did or Charlie Parker, a lot of the drummers or pianists, it's all in a book. You can open a book and go oh here's track number seven from the "Milestones" album. Okay, let me see how — and they learn stuff that way. So everything is getting so high and proficient with like harmony and technique, and everybody has all this information and knows all this and that and there's nowhere to go with it except in school. There's no jobs and nobody has the opportunity to play all the time and create their own like uniqueness. It's all in the context of the school. And I find that odd. Because it takes a really long time to get players to loosen up and open up, and when they're playing, like in my big band I see it all the time, which has a lot of young women in it. And you don't have to play all those things that you learned in school, all those phenomenal licks and all those chord substitutions. Nobody cares. Why you're going to make a living playing jazz is if you make somebody's heart go thumpeta thumpeta, thump. And you sit there and I'm always trying to say what moves you guys? And I was talking about it last night with Anat, one of our tenor players. And she's brilliant. And she's got all the chops and technique in the universe, but just to get her to go like honk be de det, and like play something and the audience is like yaaay, if she plays something interesting that's not like [scats] look how fast I can play, nobody cares.

MR: I'm so pleased to hear you say that actually.

SM: Oh good. I mean I don't care either.

MR: Because as you say, jazz has become academic and there are so many different ways to explain what people did and then you can just absorb it and do it I guess. And of course time goes by and things change, but when you talk to the older veterans, they learned on the street and they learned in the jam session. They didn't seem to need all that instruction.

SM: Yeah and you wish that people could have chances to do that now. I mean even in my — when I was first learning I would go to all those jam sessions, and I did, and I would go every night, although it was sometimes a struggle as a woman, I mean at least the person that ran the Blue Note jam session would never let me play. And then one time he said, "well you can play if you take your shirt off." And later he would say, "all right honey

he would let me play ballads for a couple of nights. And I rarely got to play. But like you're always overcoming that stupidity also, but just to be in that environment. And like you see all your peers. And then sometimes I remember at one jam session I was at the Jazz Coalition and I was sitting there and it was all night and I was dying to play. But it got like really late and it was about quarter to two and I was like oh, they're not going to ask me to play, it's too late. So I think I had three beers or something. And then the music was all great so I was happy and then I hear my name, "Sherrie Maricle." Like oh, no, because I didn't want to. And I went up to play and it was with Jon Hendricks, the singer, who just happened to be there. And there was a great bass player, Jamil Nasser and Harold Mabern, a great pianist. And I remember Jon Hendricks wanted to play "Cloudburst." You know and it was so fast. And here I am riding on three beers like in a half an hour or something. And it was all like — I mean I was grateful to the bass player — help me, you know. So it taught me a lesson. Soda pops. It's like you can never drink a speck ever and attempt to play.

MR: You better be ready when your moment comes, huh?

SM: Yeah. That was funny. That was a good lesson.

MR: Who was the guy who was — was that the fella running the jam session who was so patronizing to you?

SM: Yeah, it was Ted Curson. I don't mind saying who it is, the trumpet player, Ted Curson. I'm sure it was an event that he wouldn't remember. To him it was probably just a silly off comment, like teasing a young woman.

MR: Do you know Holly Hofmann?

SM: Yes.

MR: She told me a very, very similar story about a jam session situation.

SM: Well it's funny it happens with Diva also. We'll go to a venue and people, I mean people have actually said things to us as stupid as, "well even the professional bands don't do this," you know, meaning if we question their sound system or something. So you just look back at them with — what — and then of course the band plays and then usually the people become almost apologetic for their stupidity, you know, once they hear the band. Another known musician recently said, "God you guys sound so great, almost like a real band." And you just look at them like — and then they try to back pedal — I didn't mean that. Like okay. And so it's always really interesting and it's so funny. I mean it's not funny it's common how slow, the stuff that's socially ingrained in people's mind about what women do and what men do. It just takes so long to change it, if it ever will change, I don't know.

MR: Do you think people would — I'm not sure how to even ask this — how would it change

SM: We have had some men play with us. Sometimes, just by the nature — the band is at the highest professional level and there aren't enough women to fill the chairs sometimes. So it's not a problem with us. But like there's always the argument of, "well if you're all so good why do you have to play with each other?" which is kind of insulting. It's like well, they why don't you force — and I don't agree with the issue of like forcing Wynton— there was a big article in the paper about trying to force Wynton Marsalis to hire women or something. And I don't necessarily agree with forcing the issue. And I know that a lot of bands operate on, these are the people we like to play with because there's such a collective art form that you can't apply the same laws of labor to music and say well this has to be a split, you know three Afro-Americans, three women, two Hispanic. There's no way. It has to be the people you like to work with and the people you gel with the best in your art or it's not going to be the same band. But when we formed Diva, it was Stanley Kay's idea, and I played with him, he managed Maurice and Gregory Hines. And there was a concert with Maurice and I was just hired to play drums. And he liked the way I played and it was fantastic music. And a couple of years later he called me up and said "hey do you know women that play as good as you do?" Which to me was unbelievable because he was Buddy Rich's manager. And I said yeah. And I thought wow, he was so serious and I could tell there was no B.S. in his tone about trying to form a T&A band or anything. Because so many of the bands were, and I played in one in New York sometimes, like an all-women band, a wedding type band, a club date band, to make money, and I would see myself included, but I would see my friends that were so good, like unbelievable musicians in there on a consistent basis. And I used to feel so bad. Like why does that woman have to wear a mini-dress to play alto saxophone when she is the best, she's a great, great player and she's just not getting where she needed to be. Well anyway so that was one of my motivations, listening to Stanley and knowing how serious he was and all his influence and connections in music. And I thought good. Because my dream was to be in Woody Herman's band. And then that went by the wayside and Woody passed away so a big band and trio are my two favorite kinds of drumming. So I was like yeah I'd love to have anything to do with a big band. And I originally wasn't the leader but I was in there and helped with the original personnel and got the women together. And it was really interesting because what we were saying prior to this was was I looked at as weird as being the only girl drummer. Well everybody in the band probably had a similar experience of, "there's that girl that can play." "There's that good girl trumpet player." There is like every single person. So then all of a sudden you're in Diva and everybody plays really great. So in the first band it was so funny because I think it really knocked out of whack the egos that were like I'm unique, I'm

were all like oh, uh oh, I'm sitting next to like five other people who play just as good as I do who are my same gender. I'm not unique anymore. So it was really, really interesting.

MR: I guess.

SM: To see what happened.

MR: Who expected that that would—

SM: To see what happened in the band and everybody like kind of fighting for their solos and their space and everything. The band now is not, since 1992, is not like that anymore. It's a lot more evolved. And now the purpose of the band, it's not like a huge, bold, feminist statement, because most of — it is in one respect — but for us it's great music to play at a really high level and we have, it's amazing when you have so many fans all over the world literally and it's funny to go someplace and to hear people like screaming stuff from your CDs and I mean they just really love the band and they love the music, and they love the way we play it. They can identify like a sound with our band, you know, after a relatively short period of time, you know, seven years basically we've been working, seven or eight.

MR: Is it hard to coordinate everybody's schedule? I mean yours alone, but to get everybody together for rehearsals and to play gigs?

SM: Yeah. I think people make it a priority because they like it and as we were saying before there's not loads of places where you can get a chance to express yourself playing jazz. A lot of people in the group play Broadway shows, a lot of them play in wedding bands, some have their own bands, but you know there are clubs in New York that play for the door or then you make three dollars a night. I mean there are still fun jobs to do but it's still amazing that people can play for the door. Yeah, they make Diva I think a priority and everybody's pretty dedicated to it. Our lead trumpet player recently joined the Army. She's the first woman lead trumpet player in a military band. She's in the Army blues band.

MR: Neat.

SM: Yeah so we're having trouble getting her. Once in a while she can get free.

MR: Oh when you go to these high school competitions now, it's very common to see more girl saxophone players than guys in the sections. My own daughter plays trumpet. She's not by herself back there all the time either.

SM: We were recently in Iowa and Leisl [Sagartz] and I went ahead of time to adjudicate a high school festival, there was like twenty bands. Most of them were girls, like in every band, almost every, like one band had one boy playing tenor, all girls.

MR: Is that right?

SM: Yeah. But women somehow still, the young girls don't take it seriously. It's very rare still I think that somebody says I think I'll make jazz my career and go off and study. It still doesn't seem like an option that's really open for women. For some reason it's just not even laid out in front of them. Sure you can do this, you can do that, you can do this, or be a jazz musician. Like very common. But I think one thing that Diva does which is great is certainly role models for the young women that if they want to take it seriously that yes there is hope, and a second thing is for any students, we're the only big band that a lot of kids have ever seen live. And it's incredible that they just barrel to the stage, and colleges too. The kids say, "we never saw a big band before." And so they don't care if we're men, women or Martians, they're just are so excited that it's a big band and they never heard this kind of a sound live, you know, to me it's so sad because it is expensive to move a big band but it's really not as prohibitive as certainly not any Rock bands, but then you're of course dealing with the drawing power. Or even an artist like the heavy hitting jazz stars which command fortunes and fortunes of money for trios and things like that. But — it's well deserved but it's just too bad that some of it really seems impossibly difficult to be building new artists. And it trickles down from the media to the record companies to the agents who Stanley our manager deals with, but me once in a while and through Stanley is nobody seems to have any desire in like building a new artist up. It's like, "we'll give you a record deal but you have to be famous first" kind of thing. Like, "we'll book you on a tour but you have to have gigs first." Like some bizarre — you have to prove to us that you have a tour already then we'll book you on a tour. Like some bizarre — nobody's willing to invest in — that's one thing that I learned from Stanley that it's the music business and the business part of any business, new business, is you have to invest in it. And he's — I mean you have to. There's so many new bands. In New York alone you can go on any given day you can go to probably ten big band rehearsals somewhere and hear some great music and some awful music. Some great music with some phenomenal players. And they go here's my band, and then they don't realize all the stuff that you're going to have to pay for once things get rolling. They just think I formed a big band, here's my ten charts, send me on a tour. And then they might very well deserve but it's hard, a hard business.

MR: I've heard some complaints, mostly from what I have to describe as middle-aged white players, that the record companies these days, if they're going to back up somebody it's most likely going to be somebody pretty young and black. Is there any truth to that statement do you think?

SM: Well thinking of the two biggest singer breakthroughs, Harry Connick in the recent decade and Diana Krall, and this new woman that's being pushed pretty hard, Jane

some young white artists. But yeah, I don't know, you look at records here at this festival there's hundreds of records downstairs with phenomenal players. I don't understand how like media and marketing works but you could take any musician and I'm sure if you dump enough advertising into them they're going to have a little flicker of fame. Like as great as Diana Krall is, who I love her, I happen to be a really big fan of hers, I love the way she plays, I think she's great, but I know some other players who do similar things and who are her same age who play unbelievable piano and sing their brains out. Now I was thinking some record person could have taken this other artist for example and just put all that time, money and effort in it and come up with an equally great product. So I don't know why it's lucky, who gets picked. But I do think in Europe, and I have experienced some of the promoters there really being in love with that look of you know, young, handsome black men in suits, dancing a lot. And I mean I've heard them say things like this, like only Americans can play jazz. But it's only the women. I've never heard a male promoter say this. And there's a lot of women promoters there who talk like that. They think that that means that it's jazz, you know, for some reason there's a certain look that they're going for that people identify quickly. It might not be a middle-aged guy with a pot belly. It might not be fifteen women I don't know. But I'll tell you just one brief story, when we were playing at Tavern on the Green in New York they used to have a great jazz room there. And there was a *Jazz Times* convention, and I think about fifteen of the European promoters from all the big festivals, the North Sea and Pori and Perugia, they were all here. So Stanley said to the Tavern on the Green, "I'm going to bring all these European guys here, give us the room for the happy hour, Diva's going to play a concert and given them a cocktail hour or something." So they said, "all right." So we did a concert for all these, all of them came with their friends and guests and families. And afterwards there was a guy with a camera from Norway or something and he's talking to me and this fella said, "you're going to come to Europe this summer for eight weeks, you're going to be here for the whole festival season, we all love you, you're going to have all these gigs, this is great." And drinking, drinking, drinking. And it's like wow this is terrific. We got one concert, we played in Pori, Finland, and I asked the guy Yurkey Kengis his name is, the producer, I said, "what happened?" Not that we weren't happy we got the one gig, but I said why, we're over here and it's so common for all the festivals to share — I mean they share the airline expense and that's the huge expense of getting anybody over to Europe for this, because they all overlap so it's perfect for artists to go from one to the other. And he said to me, "well they heard you play and they liked it but when they woke up and they though it was great but when they woke up in the morning they realized they were drunk and that you're only women so it couldn't have been as

obviously hired us, but he couldn't convince the other promoters to hire us and that was the reason he told me. And I was like all right, good. But I mean it hasn't held us back from Europe. We have a good agent now. And we've been there dozens of times and played a lot of the great festivals, but we've done a lot of one-nighters in Europe. One night in Berlin. Home. One night in Rome. Home. We finally went to Europe for five weeks in the fall, we went all over the place, it was a really nice tour. A lot in Germany and we went to Croatia and Turkey and Russia and went all over. That was fun. But finally we got a good agent. But she's saying yeah, somehow it's still hard to sell. Because they're afraid it's not going to be good. They think it's going to be women in tight dresses.

MR: Like kind of a novelty thing?

SM: Yeah. We played a long midwest tour and this guy sent me an article he wrote for the paper and it said, "the last thing I wanted to do on Saturday night was go hear some all-girl band play a watered down version of 'In the Mood.'" That was how his article started. Then he went, "oh my God I was so wrong" and then he just went on to say like how just his preconception of what women musicians were like stopped him from even wanting to go. He's like, "my wife had to drag me by the ear," you know. And that's also a neat thing like a lot of the women, older women from like 60 on up, you know sometimes they'll come to the stage and go, "I played trumpet in fifth grade, this is so great and we're so happy to see women." You know and like older women get really like turned on too and they're happy to see women doing something that they didn't necessarily see in their generation.

MR: Yeah. Have you ever seen those films of the International Sweethearts — is that what it was called?

SM: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Interesting concept.

SM: And in Sherrie Tucker's new book, I don't know if you've read that, called *Swing Shift*, it's one of the best books I've ever read.

MR: I think I have that book, yeah.

SM: It's a history of the womens' swing bands from the 30s and 40s. I've never read a better researched book in my life. It's horrifying actually how women are left out of history. I mean I've cited this example to a million people but there was a band called the Darlings of Rhythm, this is from Sherrie's book, that played at the Apollo Theatre more than any other band, and it was either 1944 or 1946. And in the book, *The History of the Apollo*, they're not even mentioned once as even having ever played there. Just as an example of how they were completely ignored. Oh they're only women, they're not a real band, let's

thing to honor women — Nancy Wilson, Clora Bryant, Jane Jarvis, Diva, and we were sponsored by a Vodka company called Gray Goose Vodka. So we did this charity event for "Dress for Success" and Clora Bryant came, she's a trumpet player from Los Angeles. Do you know her well?

MR: No I don't know her well but I know the name.

SM: Well I only knew that she can't play anymore and I just knew her as that women that used to play trumpet. And she's an amazing personality. And she sent us some video of her. And I started crying when I saw her videotape. She was so, so great, like on the par easily with Dizzy Gillespie and like Louis Armstrong kind of combination. Sang her brains out, danced. And I really started to cry. I was like why isn't this woman just in the history book next to all these other guys? Because here she is, like probably one of the first Afro-American women ever on television. She was on a lot of the big T.V. talk shows playing the trumpet, she was dancing. And I saw it and I said it's so weird that me, like crawling towards 40 and studying jazz my whole life hardly know any of the women. I mean I had no clue she played this good. Or to be so stupid that I didn't know women in that day could play like that. I mean that's a stupid thing to say but it's so undocumented that it's really hard to find information.

MR: Yeah. You have to assume that nothing was happening because there's nothing there to tell you about it.

SM: Right. And then you see these little things like that kind of, and you feel bad that — I don't know if it would have changed anything about the way I grew up, you know in studying jazz, except maybe it would have been great to see somebody, an instrumentalist, somebody besides a singer being considered a woman in jazz. It might have encouraged a lot more women to go into it or something. I don't know.

MR: What inspired you to pursue your education all the way through a doctoral degree?

SM: Well this is a — this will sound — it's not lame but I mean I just wanted to move to New York. I didn't have any thoughts like — I never even though about going to graduate school, when I was at SUNY Binghamton. There was a concert there with a bassist, Michael Moore was the bass player. And I love the way he played. And my first thought was if I ever get to make a CD I'm going to ask him to play with me, which I did. But I was saying to him, "I'm going to move to New York next year, any hints like what should I do?" And he said, "well I teach at this school, NYU." I really didn't, I don't even think I'd heard of NYU. I'm like oh do they have a music department? He said, "yeah, why don't you go check it out?" So I called and I went down and I was like that might be an okay way to like slide into New York with just, instead of just going cold. So I auditioned and got in. I really didn't like it. It was not a strong department, so I was going

graduate scholarship." And then I got my master's degree and then they hired a new program director and the department started to get better. And then I was done and they said, "we don't want you to go we're going to give you a doctoral fellowship." So when you don't have any money or a job it's hard to turn down free school and a little salary. So that's maybe not the best, I didn't have like high academic aspirations, so I mean that's why I finished all my doctoral coursework and I'm embarrassed to say I was my full ten years of not writing my dissertation then had to go into the maximum amount of extensions just because I wouldn't write it. I just function much better under pressure and deadlines. So I was at the thing where if I didn't write it my whole class work was going get wiped out. So that's why I finished it.

MR: Wow. You had to get desperate.

SM: Yeah. I mean because I kept thinking what do I need it for. I didn't — I'm never a quitter so I knew that I would make myself write it.

MR: What was the dissertation on?

SM: I wrote, I analyzed, it's a history of the percussion concerto, solo percussion and orchestra. So I did a big history of that, I analyzed the concerto by Darius Milhaud, which is basically the first one for percussion and orchestra, and I wrote a concerto and analyzed that, did a performance guide, and there you have it. And I think it put me to sleep by. And somebody at NYU recently came and said, "I checked out your dissertation," I'm like oh [yawns] enjoy it as much as I did? So it wasn't really like having lofty goals to be a professor or anything. I just wanted — I thought it would be ridiculous not to finish it. And also it always motivates me that for teaching there and becoming friends with my doctoral committee and working with them professionally that well they're going to really think I'm a jackass if I don't finish this. So I didn't want to look like a quitter, and I'm not, it's just I work better under pressure.

MR: Well the whole other side of your career, a part of it is as a composer. When you started composing did you find a need to have keyboard skills? Or usually we think of a drummer, unless they go out of their way to get all the harmony study, as maybe not having that as much.

SM: Yeah well you have to, it's a requirement in school, to learn how to play the piano. How when you go into a jazz program you have to take jazz piano as well. But I mean I'm horrible, I can't play the piano, but I can play it as a writer. You know I can figure out my own chords and I can play through a passage like in slow motion until I learn it. And certainly I've studied harmony and theory, like inside out, enough to make you sick. But you know I started writing and this is also funny. Al Hamme, the person from Binghamton, he took me to — he was playing at some saxophone workshop or something

the concert. And I went to several performances that day. And I could not stand any of it. And this is how stupid I was. I said, "that music is so horrible, I bet I could write something better than that." So the first thing I wrote was this four movement suite for percussion and saxophone for Al. And we played it and it came out really good. So I was like well I can kind of do this too. I don't mean it to sound, like that sounds like egomaniacal, but for some reason, I don't mean it that way. I just was thinking, jeez, even I could try something better than this. And it could have been boom-chick boom-chick and I probably would have liked it better. But it came out that doing jazz composition and arranging is never, ever, ever ending study. To me it's so complicated, it's very sophisticated and there's so many high standards and people to idolize as writers. Somebody that I love, Tommy Newsom is a great writer, writes a lot for my band and I'm so blessed to have him.

MR: Nice charts.

SM: Yeah. And the things you can study now in arranging with Bob Brookmeyer's music and Thad Jones, and that again is the other thing where it's all, those guys just invented what they did. And for me I just go to a book and go oh, here's Thad Jones' voicing on the G7 chord. Okay, I'll steal that. So I don't have to think as hard as they did. I can just steal things from the books.

MR: Isn't that interesting how the amount of information available — is there some kind of ratio to innovation I guess. It almost doesn't make it easier because there's so much there. I can't even finish my thought but I guess I almost long for some of the old days when things just seemed to be more spontaneous or from the heart.

SM: And you could hear a player and in a second you'd know who it was. You'd know instantly if it was Louis Armstrong or Clark Terry or the difference between Dexter Gordon or Lester Young or whatever, and Johnny Hodges and Phil Woods, something totally extreme. But you could always tell right away without even — you know now, we were saying before, especially with the younger players, you listen and I would, if I took a blindfold test on new players I'd completely fail. I'd have no idea of how to identify except by tune, if you know someone's tune, but not by their soloing style necessarily. So much of it sounds the same.

MR: Well what kind of advice do you give people like that?

SM: Well the young students that are just beginning to improvise I always tell them and I mean this is true for everyone, it's not just all the notes. Yeah that's important to know what the chord is and know what scale goes with your chord, and that yes you can play it all in eighth notes and you can probably play it in thirty-second notes really fast up and down, I say but that's not really a good solo is it? No. So what's going to make your solo

you can pick one note and play it in a really swinging rhythm and that's going to be a better solo than playing five thousand notes just [scats]. And also trying — I say you can play something totally weird, just think of something emotional. Like think of an emotion and play it through your horn. If you want anger, like I just had one girl on a tenor saxophone trying to play a low B flat. I'm like come on — we were playing a B flat blues — just honk on a B flat, just go hooonk, like as loud as you can for like two measures. And she did it and all her band mates were cheering. Because meanwhile she was trying to play like [scats]. That was her solo before. And I'm like that's not a solo. I said pick one of those notes and just play it. And that's just to start a kid out. But I actually think it translates to people that are at a really sophisticated level of technique and harmonic knowledge too. Nobody, really, I mean I fall asleep after like one chorus of being impressed with wow they have amazing chops. Wow listen to that, ooh listen to that harmony. But it's usually the same rhythm [scats] all like constant eighth notes forever, with wow how impressive your chops are. Then after like the fourth chorus— it's like when somebody talks in your face like I'm doing to you, nonstop, but with no inflection or anything, just like you know, like nonstop like this forever the same exact timbre to everything. And that's what some people's solos start sounding like. Even though what I'm saying might be incredibly brilliant but I'm saying it all exactly the same way. That's like an analogy that I think applies to a lot of players and myself included sometimes.

MR: Do you have a list of must-listen-to drummers for young players?

SM: Well, Mel Lewis is one of my absolute idols. I think he swings. Big band drummers I divide into two categories, Mel Lewis for sure and I love Buddy Rich, I always loved Buddy Rich. He's like one of the, you know you can pick out the geniuses like Oscar Peterson on the piano and Buddy, like people who do, and Art Tatum, people who could play what nobody will ever be able to duplicate what these people have done, and he's one of those. I love Jeff Hamilton right now who is a drummer in Los Angeles, one of my favorite players. Dennis Mackrel I think is a great drummer. And I love all the Jo Jones and all the great drummers with the Basie bands. I mean I have a really long listening list I make all my students take. And you've got to listen to — go find one of these records. And for small group playing I love Philly Joe Jones, he's probably one of my favorite players. Yeah. And Elvin Jones. I just — the list is endless.

MR: What's the IAJE — do they have a mission to increase the audience for jazz as well as the players?

SM: They do have a mission statement but I don't have it memorized, I don't know what it is. But I would think that that would be a really important aspect of education. Actually now that you're mentioning I find it kind of missing from what they're doing and I think that

artists too. And this is the other funny part that makes me laugh. You get out of school, you have all these chops and you're a great player, and then like I said, you go to the audience and the audience wants to hear "Take the A Train" again for the twenty millionth time in their life. They don't want to hear your new song that's the coolest harmony in the world. They want to hear "Take the A Train" and they want to hear it straight ahead and so that's always finding the balance like to keep the audiences interested. And that's something — I mean when I was in school I wrote the outest music, I made all these recordings with my friends and we thought that oh this is so hip, this is great, we're going to be it. "Could you play 'Take the A Train' please?"

MR: I've often wondered what would happen at one of these jazz parties if somebody announced, "okay, now we're going to do an original composition."

SM: Well we have that in Five Play, our quintet here, we do some different kinds of arrangements. But we can't, we wouldn't do it. And the other thing that, even though musicians are artists, and they certainly are, but you have to remember the only reason you're on the stage is because there's an audience there. They paid money to see you. You owe them something. And the audience would owe us respect to present something that they like but you have to know where you're going and gauge your program towards that. And I love playing "Take the A Train," and I love just swinging and I love playing stuff that's a little weirder too. But you just have to know who you're playing for, and hope not to, it's like that's the business part. You have to pay attention to it.

MR: Right.

SM: And I don't know how to educate audiences to, you know, you must like this new kind of harmony, or that kind of thing, like to get people to like that. Because the diversity between a festival like this and some of the — well now you can't even really count some of the festivals as jazz festivals because the headliners will be James Brown and Earth Wind & Fire, things that have nothing to do with jazz at all but they've become just big music festivals just to keep the crowd interested. And again it's a whole trickle down system of what the record company and the media promotes, and what people hear on the radio all the time. If there were more jazz stations — like my nieces and nephews, they never would hear jazz if they didn't come to my — I see them at concerts and they're falling asleep by the third song, but they don't even have a chance to hear it. Like if it was in people's faces more, if you drove by and saw a billboard with the Count Basie band instead of Ricky Martin or something. You know, if people were just aware of it more then I think they might have an interest in seeing the concerts.

MR: Well you know jazz I think takes some work to listen to. I think it's not as easily accessible to peoples' ears somehow. A lot of people don't understand — oh I like jazz

until they stop playing the melody. They don't quite know how to listen to it and I'm not sure that they really should.

SM: It also boils down to the way that it's presented also. And the artist. Like someone who I idolize with their stage presence and something I always try to learn from people who are great band leaders and understand what — I mean you can warm up to somebody really fast, you can really like someone even if you're not a hundred percent convinced you like the music they're playing. Like Clark [Terry] is so open and so warm and he's just so, it's like he just walks out and gives the audience a big hug or something. And he does a lot of original tunes, but they're sort of stylized so people will like be comfortable with the feel his group plays with. They don't play anything crazy or play free or sound like the drums are falling down a flight of stairs or anything. But he does a lot of original music. And Flip Phillips, who was here last year, who just played so great, played a lot of original stuff, music he wrote on "Sweet Georgia Brown," on those chord changes. We play one of his songs based on "I Got Rhythm," that's called "The Claw." We played it yesterday and the audience loved it but they don't know that song. They could never sing that song. That song has a really fast bebop head that would be like alien to an audience like this. But it was Flip Phillips and it's straight ahead swing, and maybe they recognized the "I Got Rhythm" chord changes, I don't know. But there's ways to do it and to present it and find a combination that doesn't make it so difficult. And if you have — a lot of jazz musicians are, you know, my friends used to say "yeah isn't it weird, jazz musicians think jazz is an open wound let's pour salt in it, we just have to suffer, and be all like suffering for our art because this is the blues." And it's like uh huh. Hey all right. I don't think so. And they look so serious. And a lot of artists are so introverted and so like just into their art, I'm an artist, I'm going to be as weird as possible and alienate you and turn my back to you. You know and it's like no, it's not fun. I like to have fun when I play, and I always do. And I think the audience reacts to that also, rather than they get scared if you're all serious and dark and crazy acting, and they're like, "ooh, what are we listening to?" I mean you could play "Take the A Train" with a weird attitude and scare people too.

MR: I love it when people do creative things, even with someone last night was doing—

SM: "Sunny Side of the Street."

MR: "Sunny Side of the Street." And they were playing it in two keys.

SM: Yeah. C and E flat. Yeah.

MR: And I couldn't figure out what was going on for a minute. I thought I knew what song this was and then it shifted and I'm going that was really neat. Wasn't your tenor player playing in that set I think?

SM: Yeah, Anat. An interesting thing, since you mentioned Anat is also what I'm finding really fascinating is well I'm the only American in my quintet first of all. But the women in Diva are literally women from all over the world. That's really fascinating also, how our alto player, Karolina Strassmayer comes from Bad Mitterndorf, Austria, this little tiny village. Her dad is like a forest ranger. You know how the heck did she come out playing — like an unbelievable jazz player. She a genius, a brilliant jazz player. And just like the impact of music, and Anat from Israel and Nicki and our bass player Nicki's sister Lisa, they're from Australia. Nicki plays bari sax [error, Nicki plays bass and Lisa plays bari sax] in our big band, and we have rhythm section players, two players from Japan and we have a girl from Italy playing tenor sax with us. People, just women from all over but I think that's pretty amazing.

MR: That's interesting. If this was an all-guy band and you had those same nationalities they would probably promote it as an international type band. But you've got two kinds of interesting identities to your band. It's great.

SM: But I was in a position when I first started playing and recording and I mentioned about Michael Moore and I did get a chance to play with him on a CD. I would never hire a woman, ever. It didn't even occur to me to hire a woman when I first started like doing my own projects and I was actually in grad school and I met my boyfriend John, we're not together now, but he was a great alto player. We did two CDs together, did some recording. Never would it even have occurred to me for any reason to hire a woman. I mean nobody mentioned it. We're just like let's get these players we like and there wasn't even a woman that would have come to my mind at all. Which is interesting. And even so I would have been skeptical just because, I don't know if women will admit it, but I admit my ignorance too, thinking I had the stereotype too. And I was not like, I was different than the stereotype, so I'm serious and I want to be a really good player, and I'm not going to be one of those T&A women with the lipstick and short skirt trying to play jazz bad. You know play the sad version of "In the Mood" to make two hundred dollars in my miniskirt. So to me whenever I heard all-women bands I was like, you know, sure. So I became enlightened myself. And I also found though that like in the big band there's fifteen players. We are extremely lucky if there's one substitute for every chair. Just because the quality of the band is so high and there aren't enough women to fill the chairs that play. And you go from the level of what the professional player is in Diva, and then like one notch down. I mean the gap is like this. It goes professional and very student. There's not too much of a trickle up. It's either you're really, really good and you've taken it seriously or else you're at a student level. With men it's easy to call like twenty people right off the bat that are all equally qualified. So that's a problem.

MR: Let me ask you the question about you're on a desert island and you can take five CDs or LPs.

SM: Okay. Well see I'll tell you that in a second. But what I was going to tell you, I'm sorry I got off my track with the not hiring women and stuff. But now like with Diva and Five Play, I don't know if it's the people, because I work with them all the time anyway, but like our bass player, I used to have this incredible fantasy. I always wanted to play a shuffle with Ray Brown. It's like I love Ray Brown. But now I mean I love playing with Nicki. I think she's one of the best bass players I know. And now it just becomes a matter of, you know there's just certain players, it doesn't matter that Nicki is a woman or a man or whatever she is, she's just my favorite, like one of my absolute favorite bass players. So now you have wider choices. And for me it's kind of neat because I don't have to think oh, the women thing again. Because it never, never occurs to me. Like it never occurred to me before to hire a woman. Now it never occurs to me to worry like, oh, should I hire a man, should I hire a woman. I mean I never think of that. I just think who do I like. And I'm lucky now that I'm not so, I'm much more enlightened than I was. Okay so my five CDs. I would take a Buddy Rich compilation CD or his "Big Swing Face" album which I love, I would take one of my Mel Lewis albums — I'd have to think about which one to take, probably the one with "Groove Merchant" on it. Mel Lewis. I'd probably take — I can't tell you this, I have to wittle down my list, but I'd take a Ray Brown trio album with Jeff Hamilton and Gene Harris on it. Probably an Oscar Peterson trio album, and maybe probably a Frank Sinatra record or Ella Fitzgerald. I don't know. I need more time to prepare.

MR: Only five? That's not enough. Well this has really been a fascinating conversation. I wish you all the best in the future.

SM: Thank you.

MR: And you're going on tour coming up with any of your groups soon?

SM: Yeah. We're booking a tour with Nancy Wilson, actually with the big band. And our first concert is going to be at the Tanglewood jazz weekend this Labor Day. And we're doing our fourth CD in May, a live CD, we're doing five dates with Diana Schur at the Manchester Craftsman's Guild, which is a phenomenal place in Pittsburgh, like very state-of-the-art audio/video recital hall. It's an amazing, amazing place. And we're going to record all five halves of our concert and hopefully we'll get one good live CD out of it. So that's our two big projects coming up.

MR: Well I wish you luck in all that juggling.

SM: Thanks.

MR: I think it's a good role model for people, that there's lots of different ways to make a

SM: Yeah. With the performance aspect though we're really lucky to have Stanley. Like no kidding. We could have a million big bands but he really knows the business part very well and he was willing to invest a lot of his money to get us rolling. I mean we commission all of our own music, all of our music is original to us, both the small group and the big band. And just with our PR person, Virginia Wiggs, and it's a big expense and he's invested a lot and he's like a little angel for us. So we're lucky for that.

MR: Great. Well thanks for your time today.

SM: You're welcome. Thank you.